An awakening leads some people to make dramatic life changes to pursue FI. For others, becoming aware of the concept of FI is the only change necessary to start experiencing the benefits of FI.

A great example was shared by a physician named Jeff who blogs as *The Happy Philosopher*. He felt he was burning out less than five years into his career. He recalls a conversation in which he was informed that “you need ten million dollars to retire.” Conventional wisdom says it takes an incredible amount of money to achieve FI. You often hear that you need enough assets to replace 80 to 90 percent of the income that you had in your prime working years to retire.

FI is, in part, about building wealth. One way that we in the FI community think about money differently from the average person is how we define wealth. FI is not about needing an absolute amount, like a million dollars, or maybe needing ten million if you are a high-earner like the good doctor. FI is all about the amount of money you *need* relative to the cost of the lifestyle you *desire*.

This can seem like a subtle distinction, and it may seem obvious to those who are already on the path to FI. However, for those steeped in conventional ways of thinking about money, this